

THE CLAUDE BEAST

PRD: Product Requirements Documents

How PRDs became the most important input for AI-assisted development

start.io | Agentic Development Series | 2026

PRDs have evolved from human alignment documents to AI programming interfaces



TRADITIONAL PRDs

- Alignment artifact between humans
- Monolithic documents for holistic comprehension
- Optional nice-to-have documentation
- Code was the source of truth



AI-ERA PRDs

- Programming interface for AI agents
- Sequential, dependency-ordered phases with testable criteria
- Essential input that determines output quality
- Intent is the source of truth

The PRD-to-Plan-to-Todo methodology is the gold standard for AI-assisted development teams

1 PRD

WHAT to build

- Requirements & features
- Acceptance criteria
- Constraints & non-goals
- Business logic

2 PLAN

HOW to build it

- Files to create/modify
- Technical approach
- Dependencies between steps
- Complexity estimates

3 TODO

Tasks to execute

- Numbered implementation steps
- Wait for approval per step
- Track task completion
- Update docs after each phase

Every major AI coding platform converges on the same Specify > Plan > Tasks > Implement pattern

Platform	Workflow Pattern	Config File
Claude Code	Explore-Plan-Code-Commit	CLAUDE.md
GitHub	Spec-driven development	Spec Kit
Cursor	Plan-critique-execute	.cursorrules
Replit	Plan Mode / Build Mode	.replit
JetBrains Junie	Research-then-implement	.junie
Google Antigravity	Mission Control + Tasks	AGENTS.md
AGENTS.md -- an open standard jointly launched by Google, OpenAI, Factory, Sourcegraph, and Cursor -- is emerging as the cross-platform agent specification file.		

AI is most valuable as a thinking partner, not a replacement for human judgment

THE DEVELOPMENT FUNNEL

Brainstorm

Generate ideas freely

User Research

Validate against real needs

Product Brief

Distill into opportunity statement

PRD

Formalize into structured requirements

Plan

Translate to technical architecture

Tasks

Break into implementable units

Code

Implement systematically

FOUR CORE TECHNIQUES

Full Context

Provide related docs, templates, user research via @-mentions

Socratic Questioning

Use structured questioning to sharpen thinking before writing

Multiple Approaches

Generate 2-3 strategies; compare and select the best

Multi-Perspective Review

Get feedback from engineer, executive, and user researcher personas via sub-agents

The specification is the source of truth -- master it, and AI becomes your multiplier



01 PRDs are now essential

They're the primary input that determines AI output quality

02 Always plan first

PRD > Plan > Todo > Code. Never jump to implementation

03 Structure over prose

Bullets, sections, numbers. Think of PRDs as AI input format

04 Phase your work

5-6 phases, 30-50 requirements each, 5-15 min per agent phase

05 State non-goals positively

AI cannot infer from omission. Every boundary must be explicit

06 Research before you specify

LLM training data goes stale. Verify current capabilities first

07 Use "DO NOT CHANGE"

Protect stable code from AI over-optimization

08 AI as thinking partner

Combine human judgment with AI context processing power